spring '91

# thamesmead focus







Bill's dramatic discovery

Versapak's Olympic success

Europe: What's in it for Thamesmead?



# The GREENWICH TRAINING Co. Ltd.

A London Borough of Greenwich initiative promoting training

The Greenwich Training Company Ltd is an approved training organisation, currently funded to deliver a range of quality training programmes in line with the Department's unemployment initiatives for all 16-59 year olds, through Training Credits, Training for Work or Community Action.

**Qualifications to NVQ levels 1, 2 & 3 are available in the following skill areas:**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Carpentry | Welding & Fabrication | Painting & decorating |
| Plumbing | Electrical/Electronics | Word power |
| Bricklaying | Business Administration | Number power |
| Catering | Finance | Information Technology |
| Childcare | Information Technology | Brick Laying |

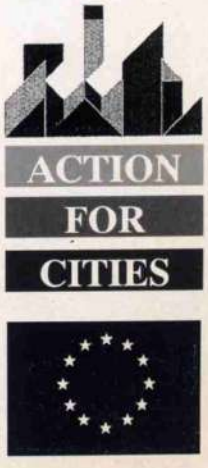
***All occupational areas are supported by full programme of literacy, numeracy and English for second language speakers.***

If you have been unemployed & signing on for 12 months and you already have a skill, you could join a community action project. If you would like to put your skill to good use in the community & voluntary sector studying alongside a part time course then give us a call. The part time course will help you with such things as C.V. preparation, job search skills and selling yourself.

A similar Arts & Media project also exists for people in the entertainment business.

We operate the largest training scheme in the Borough, with in house training where you will benefit from the resources of a large organisation, without losing the personal one to one contact.

**To apply for your place or for further information please ring: 081 316 5560 Ext 178 or 168**



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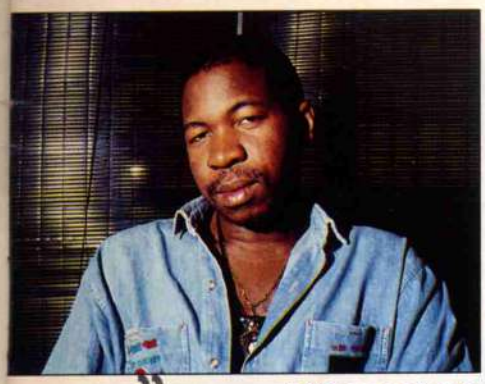
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*Price of the European Parliament*



*£6 million tur over compar thrives Thamesmea*



*Recently unearthed remains give a picture of times gone by*

## Briefly

● Hunters Plastics has removed three unsightly silos from its site on the Woolwich Industrial Estate. Towering over the site for twelve years they have provided a famous land mark for visitors but a new computerised process control system means that they are no longer needed.

● The Ridgeway embankment is to receive a £140,000 revamp, which will make it a pleasant walkway for the public with a footpath link up to the River Walk through the golf course. The money is coming from a derelict land grant and the Urban Partnership Fund.

● The Wildfowler Public House in the Moorings is to get a face-lift and a new name. More news will follow in the next issue.

● Jane Alexander, Thamesmead Town's Animal Warden, has been appointed as the official Dog Warden for the London Borough of Bexley in the Thamesmead area.

● The Thamesmead Advisory Forum is writing to the Prime Minister and local MPs and Councillors about its concern regarding the effectiveness of the Dangerous Dogs Act.

● Well-known Thamesmead resident Fred Orford, 75, ran the London Marathon in five hours and five minutes.

● Thamesmead Town Chairman Sir James Melon went through the finishing line at four hours and 33 minutes.

**Saturday 23 April saw the results of the residents' elections for three Directors to sit on the Board of Thamesmead Town. There are nine Elected Directors, with three seats coming up for re-election each year. David Irons was voted in for the Waterfield area, Albert Devereux for the Crossway area and Katharine Galloway for the Parkview area. Pictured on the left is David Irons, centre, Katharine Galloway and right, Albert Devereux with his grandson.**




# Estate gets face lift and a new name

Improvements to the Woolwich Industrial Estate, a prime location for business investors, are likely to create more jobs in the area.

The Estate, which is to be renamed Thamesmead Business Park, has been awarded a grant, obtained by Thamesmead Town and the London Borough of Greenwich as part of an Urban Partnership Fund scheme.

The grant is additional to the one received last year and is enabling large-scale improvements to take place on the Estate. The decision to change the Estate's name was made in consultation with the Estate's business tenants.

Fifty per cent of the fund comes from the Government, the remaining 50% coming from private sources: the London Borough of Greenwich, Thamesmead Town, the Estate's business tenants and Thames Water Utilities.

The original Government grant, awarded last year, was for £125,000, which meant a total expenditure of £250,000. The new grant, awarded recently, is for £80,000, which will mean a grand total expenditure of £330,000 on improvements.

The money will be used for improving the appearance of Nathan Way, re-landscaping the junction with Eastern Way, putting up a large floodlit sign with the Estate's new name on it, improving security and planting 40 trees and some shrubs, grass and flower beds. Derelict buildings have been demolished to make way for new improvements and increased lighting has been fitted in the Boughton Road area to discourage thieves.

# Two non-exec directors join board

**In April, the Board of Thamesmead Town appointed two non-executive Directors.**

**Ted Watts and Ann Rennie were appointed to bring additional skills and knowledge to the Company as it develops its business plans for the future.**

**Ann Rennie followed a successful career at the National Westminster bank plc with an appointment to the Board of Reed Executive.**

**Ted Watts is a past President of the Royal Institute of Chartered Surveyors and is Chairman of property and design consultancy Watts and Partners.**

**A third non-executive appointment is expected to be made shortly.**

# Residents' Charter – available for comment

Thamesmead Services Limited has just published a draft of a new Residents' Charter designed to inform residents about how the Company's Housing Department operates and its aims for service delivery. The Charter covers every area of housing management including lettings and technical services as well as complaints and compensation.

When it is finalised, every customer of the housing department will receive a copy of the Charter.

There is an opportunity for residents to comment on the draft version in a consultation period which runs up to 10 June 1994.

Residents who would like the opportunity to comment can request a copy of the draft from Thamesmead Town's Public Relations Office on 081 310 1500, extension 270. Comments should be back with Housing Director Bob Collins before the deadline of 10 June.

Subject to comments received, it is intended that the new Residents Charter will be finally approved by the Thamesmead Board at the July meeting.



**Thamesmead Town Chairman Sir James Mellon visited Southlake Primary School a few days after their highly successful operatic performance of The Prodigal Son. This was produced in conjunction with the Christian group Opera Brava and Bexley Arts Forum. Sir James gave the morning assembly, telling the children about the years he had spent in Ghana, West Africa. It was a lively occasion, with lots of participation from the children.**

## 'Loose fit' for lettings policy

Changes to Thamesmead Town's property letting policy include a new 'loose fit' approach.

Applicants will now be eligible for any property type and 'loose fit' property allocation will be made if supply exceeds demand. Under the revised policy - anyone 20 years old or over can apply and flat sharing will be allowed.

An Easy Reference Lettings Guide, listing all the main points of the policy, is available from Thamesmead Town's Residential Lettings Team on 081 310 1500.

## Free advice for lone parents

An open day for lone parents is to be held in Woolwich offering free advice on affordable childcare, benefits, training, further education, business start-up and employment.

The event, called Stepping Stones for Lone Parents will be held at Woolwich Town Hall on Wednesday, May 18 from 9.30am-5.00. Grants may be available to help people return to work.

A similar event is planned, to take place later in the year in Thamesmead.

# Seminar for budding Entrepreneurs

Last month a day's seminar called Start Your Own Business was held in the Thamesmead Town conference facilities.

The seminar was held by the Greenwich Enterprise Board, South Thames Training and Enterprise Council, SOLOTEC (South London Training and Enterprise Council), Thamesmead Town and the Prince's Youth Business Trust.

The day was aimed at giving Thamesmead residents the opportunity to receive advice on becoming self employed.

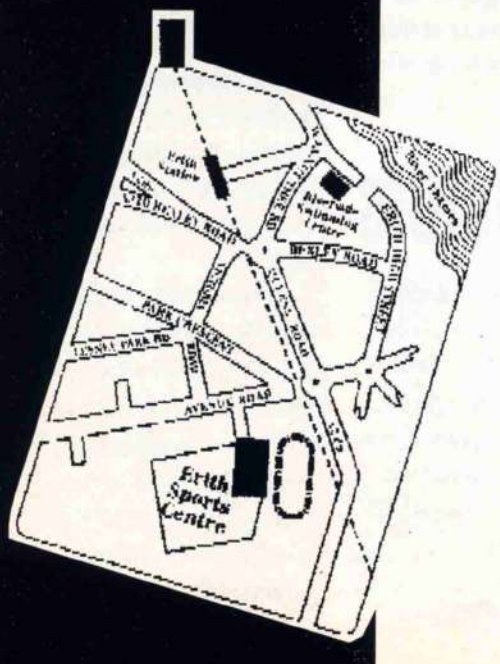
Legal, practical, funding and training issues were covered, as well as personal development.

The day was a pilot scheme, but was such a success that all involved are planning a similar day. The seminar was well attended and most of the people who went along are now involved further in the process of starting up their own businesses.

# Erith Sports Centre

**ERITH SPORTS CENTRE**
Avenue Road
Erith
**0322 350271**

**CROOK LOG SPORTS CENTRE**
Brampton Road
Bexleyheath
**081-304 5386**




**For less than £6.50 per week (£4.50 per week at off peak times) you can be a member of the**

**Busy Bodies Fitness Collection**

**for this weekly fee you can visit our hi-tech fitness studio and any of our fitness classes - free of charge - as many times as you want.**

**We have our 10 fitness classes to choose from each week Bums and Tums, Step Aerobics, Slide, Aerobics, Circuit Training and our creche operates from 9.15am to 3.30pm each day.**

**If the Fitness Collection is not for you why not come down and join in a fitness class - membership is not essential.**

**Erith Sports Centre also provides junior activities, badminton, five-a-side and has bar and catering facilities for small and large functions.**

**Our new Activity Programme for Erith Sports Centre and Crook Log Sports Centre is available please pop in or telephone to receive more details.**

Managed by
Leisure Link
for
Bexley
LONDON BOROUGH



## Thamesmead in Bloom

Entries for the Thamesmead in Bloom competition must be received by May 30. Send entries to Thamesmead Town, Freepost, Harrow Manor Way, SE2 9XH.

## Urgent Call for Escorts

Bexley Association of Disabled People's Shopmobility Scheme is in urgent need of volunteer escorts to push elderly, disabled and partially sighted people in wheelchairs around Bexleyheath Broadway Shopping Centre.

The Shopmobility Scheme is available on Tuesdays and Fridays from 10am to 3pm and can be used by any member of the public who wishes to borrow a wheelchair and/or needs an escort to push them around to do their shopping.

If you can spare a couple of hours a week or would like to use the scheme yourself, call 081- 301 5237 or 0322 523047.

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**Thamesmead Focus is published by Thamesmead Town Registered in England Company registration no. 2022523 Registered office: Harrow Manor Way, Thamesmead South, London SE2 9XH. Company Limited by guarantee**

# Local pioneer retires after 21 years

Doris Grimsley has retired from Thamesmead Town after 21 years of service. In this time Doris, now 59, never took a day's sick leave. When Thamesmead was in its early stages, Doris worked for the civil engineers at site offices. She saw much of the early building work going on.

'We were pioneers in those days,' she says.

Cycling between the various site portacabins where she worked, Doris says she was always climbing over sand and rubble and had a few near scrapes.

In heavy snow, she was driven to a site in a Land Rover. She stepped out of the car, promptly fell into a snow drift and was buried up to the top of her head! 'Those days were exciting times,' she remembers.



Doris will now continue and expand upon her hobbies of pantomime costume-making, creative writing, keep fit, swimming and tap-dancing.



### • Sessional Childcare Worker

Age 25+

Recognised qualification or previous experience of working with 5- 11 year- olds required. Must hold current clean driving licence. Vacancy for term time only. Wage: £6.00 per hour

Times: 7.45am - 9.15am Mon- Fri

Area: Abbey Wood

Job no 0336

### • Sales Service Engineer

Age 20- 25

Trainee sales service engineer required to sell and install industrial equipment, work involves 10% cold calling. Electrical experience and clean current driving licence essential. May suit ex- telecom person. Starting from Charlton office each day. Company car available.Wage: £700 per month plus commission (possibility of earning between £270 and £900 commission per month.) Times: 8.30 am - 5pm Mon- Fri

Area: London/home counties.

Job no: 0329

### • Sheet Metal Operatives

Age open

Two skilled or semi skilled operatives required with experience of CNC turret press, press brakes, spotwelding and general sheet metalwork. Ability to read working drawings a distinct advantage but training considered. Wage: £8,872 - £10,140 per annum Times: 11.20pm - 7,30am Mon- Fri

Area: Thamesmead

Job no: WOW 0360

### • Deputy Manager

Age 21+

Person required to sell office equipment through busy retail outlet. Will be advising customers on product. Experience of administration and stock control essential. Must have previous experience in dealing with customers - computer knowledge, fax etc.

Wage: £9,000- £11,000 per annum plus £2,000 bonus

Times: 40 hours per week - times will vary between evenings and some weekends

Area: Charlton

Job no: WOW 0350

### • Furniture Maker

Age open

Experienced and highly skilled bespoke furniture maker required.Wage: £6.00 per hour Times: 40 hours per week

Area: Charlton

Gas Inspector - temp 3 months

Age open

Must be Corgi registered and have own transport, will be inspecting domestic appliances. Must be hard working and reliable, current clean driving licence essential. Wage: £7.25 per hour Times: 8am- 5pm Mon- Fri

Area: Shooters Hill (SE3)

Job no: WOW 0379

**For all advertised jobs contact Woolwich Arsenal ESJ on 081- 854 2441 extensions 216 or 130, quoting job number.**

# GREENWICH COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Headquarters: Corelli Road SE3 8EP Tel: (081) 319 8088 Fax: (081) 319 8040

**Greenwich Community College offers part-time day and evening courses for adults and young people. With nearly 1400 courses on offer on 29 sites, the college provides a wide range of subjects from sports to languages, from computer studies to local history. In fact, the college offers a variety of life-long learning opportunities for the whole of the community of Greenwich, working with all ages of students at every stage of their lives.**

Terry Powley, the college's Principal, emphasises the broad span of the college: "The college has something to offer everybody at each stage of their life - children, young people, parents learning alongside their children, adults studying for general interest or gaining a qualification, senior citizens making constructive use of their retirement. For all generations, the college is a local, friendly place to study".

## CRECHES

Many day-time courses are supported by a creche and take place at times which fit into school hours. The college's creches are for children aged 0-5 years, whose parents or carers are attending classes at the college. Staff are trained to take good care of children and to provide them with a range of stimulating and interesting activities. All of the activities, such as painting, play doh, sand and water play, are designed to help children gain confidence and enjoy themselves.

## PARENT/CHILD WORKSHOPS

Parent/child workshops offer the opportunity for people of all ages - from toddlers to grandparents - to have fun learning together. The workshops concentrate on a specific activity, ranging from gymnastics to pottery, from circus skills to computers. The college also puts on half-term and holiday workshops which provide a carousel of activities and experiences which allows parents/guardians and children to learn together.

## CHILDREN'S CLASSES IN THE PERFORMING ARTS

The college offers a number of courses for children. There is a concentration on the performing arts at the Kidbrooke Centre on Saturday mornings. Greenwich Youth Dance meets from 9.30am to 12.30pm, and the Greenwich Music Makers provide group tuition in strings, recorders and guitars from 10am to 12 noon. The Greenwich Community Performing Arts Project, which is a collaborative venture between the college and Crown Woods School, takes place every Tuesday from 4.30 onwards at Crown Woods School.

## YOUNG PEOPLE

The college runs classes for young people at its centres at Thomas Tallis, Waterfield, Abbey Wood and Kings Park. The centres offer purposeful out-of-school learning experiences for young people in such diverse subject areas as computers, heritage languages, music, snorkelling, baby care, counselling and sports. The college also runs the Southmere Boating Centre which introduces young people to sailing and canoeing.

## LANGUAGES FOR ADULTS AND FAMILIES

The college offers over 100 courses in 21 different languages. This breadth of offer is presented in a diversity of class styles, extending from weekly classes to full-time intensive courses for people in business. All tutors are highly qualified and are usually native speakers.

The college has an excellent record of success from students sitting external examinations. It prepares students for the following examinations:

- Institute of Linguists
- Cambridge Certificate
- GCSE and 'A' levels

Whether for examinations, holidays, travel or business, all the college's courses set out to develop the student's ability to use a foreign language effectively for practical communication in every day situations.

The college also runs **family language workshops.** These give an opportunity for parents with children from the age of 5 to study Japanese, German, French or Spanish in a pleasant atmosphere through the medium of language games and songs. From September, classes will take place at the Burrage Centre (Mondays from 4-5.30pm), at the Waterfield Centre (Wednesdays from 4-5.30pm) and at the Haimo Centre (Saturdays from 10am-12 noon).

## ARTS AND CRAFTS

The college offers students an extensive programme of general education, ranging from art to photography, lacemaking to bookbinding. For example, the college runs **craft workshops** at a number of centres, which are for local people who want to learn about various clothesmaking, textile and craft activities for the benefit of themselves, their children, family and neighbours. Activities include sewing skills, basketry, chair caning, soft and wooden toymaking, curtains, cushions, patchwork, embroidery and much more. **Machine knitting** courses are available for those who have never used a knitting machine before, wish to learn the basic techniques and are thinking of buying a machine. Level 2 courses are for people who wish to extend their basic knowledge of techniques and design.

## WORKING WITH NEIGHBOURHOOD GROUPS

The college also works closely with local tenants' groups and community groups and offers a range of courses specially for them. The college may be able to support the educational activities of community groups on topics of community concern and relevance.

## OPEN LEARNING CENTRE

The Open Learning Centre is a new opportunity for learning in a purpose built centre at Greenwich Park Centre, Royal Hill, SE10.

The centre is open to Greenwich Community College students and to anyone who wishes to study independently in a friendly, supportive atmosphere.

**At the centre you can:**

- improve your skills in English and Maths
- study at a pace and time that suits you
- seek advice and guidance for further study
- have access to a variety of learning materials
- spend individual time with a tutor
- use a computer for word processing, data handling or graphic design
- develop your study skills
- spend more time on your chosen subject

For further information and advice about the Open Learning Centre phone (081) 293 9413.

## LEARNING FOR WORK

The college has been funded by the South Thames Training and Enterprise Council to set up training courses to help people who are long term unemployed gain qualifications which will be of benefit to them in obtaining employment. The college is offering courses in music, clothesmaking, access and language for work. All participants must have been unemployed for at least 12 months at the 1st September 1993. They are able to study for 21 hours a week and still receive benefit. Those eligible and interested should phone Rosemary Hill on (081) 319 8088 or make contact with her at the college's headquarters, Kidbrooke Centre, Corelli Road, London SE3 8EP.

## GATEWAYS TO OPPORTUNITY

The college has been funded by the South Thames Training and Enterprise Council to offer professional and impartial advice on the full range of employment, training and educational opportunities. Those who are unemployed may be eligible to redeem a voucher at the college, and the advice available will help them to identify a new start in training, adult education or further education, or work. For further information, ring the Outcomes project on (081) 293 9888 between 9.30am and 5pm; or phone Caroline James on (081) 850 3632.

## ACCREDITED COURSES

The college's accredited courses enable adult students to gain certificates and recognised qualifications, ranging from GCSEs and 'A' levels to the courses accredited by boards such as the City and Guilds, the Royal Society of Arts and the Central Council for Physical Recreation. The college also provides a number of courses - such as Fresh Start, Return to Study and Making Experience Count - which allow many adults to have a second chance at taking advantage of educational opportunities.

**GREENWICH COMMUNITY COLLEGE is pleased to announce that their new prospectus of courses for 1994/95 will be available in College Centres, Borough offices, libraries and other venues from Monday May 23rd. If you wish to study for a qualification come to the accredited enrolment sessions on:**

- **Wednesday June 22nd:** 10.00-1.00 &6.00-9.00 at Burrage Grove Centre, Burrage Grove, SE18.
- **Thursday June 23rd:** 10.00-1.00 at Haimo Rd. Centre, Haimo Rd, SE9
- **Thursday June 23rd:** 6.00-9.00 at Greenwich Park Centre, Royal Hill, SE10

Your nearest Centre is Waterfield Centre, Waterfield Close, Bentham Road, SE28. From September this centre will be offering classes in First Aid, Child Psychology, Clothesmaking, Computing, Crafts, Sound Recording Engineering, Exercise to Music, French, Fresh Water Fishing, Soft Furnishing, Picture framing, Word Processing, Painting, Book-keeping, Music and English for speakers of other languages. There are courses for all ages including parent and child classes and youth classes. This centre is also the home of Thamesmead Music Club for children of 8+ which meets on Thursday from 4.00 to 5.30.

***For more information, pick up a prospectus or return the coupon to: The Course Support Unit, Haimo Rd., SE9 6DZ***

**PART-TIME COURSES**
**Please send me information on:**
***(Please tick)***

☐ Art & Design ☐ Business Studies
☐ Care ☐ Computers ☐ Counselling
☐ Crafts ☐ Engineering ☐ English
☐ Fashion ☐ Food Studies ☐ Furniture
☐ Crafts ☐ Floristry/Gardening
☐ Health Studies ☐ Languages ☐ Maths
☐ Music ☐ Nautical Studies ☐ Photography
☐ Pottery ☐ Sign Language
☐ Social Sciences ☐ Soft Furnishing
☐ Sport & Leisure ☐ Study Skills.

**I am particularly interested in the following course(s).**

.....
.....
.....

Name: .....
Address:.....
.....
..... Tel. No.: .....

# Our Price's Euro Vision of Thamesmead

**On June 9, the British people will have the chance to vote for candidates in the European Elections. We interviewed Peter Price, the MEP currently responsible for Thamesmead.**

**What is your title, who do you represent and to which party do you belong?**
I am the Member of the European Parliament for the constituency of Bromley, Bexley and Greenwich, which covers the whole of the Thamesmead area, and I belong to the Conservative Party.

**How do you divide your time between the UK and the EC?**
I am in Strasbourg or Brussels for four days during the week and return to the UK on Thursday night. I attend meetings, go to social functions and catch up with my correspondence at the weekend, then return to work on Monday morning.

**Isn't that terribly tiring?**
It is.

**How long have you been an MEP?**
For 15 years. Not always for this constituency.

**How do you stay in touch with local issues?**
I meet constantly with all sorts of local organisations. . I keep an eye on developments in the Thamesmead area.

**So you don't hold a surgery?**
No, the area is too big, I would spend the whole time holding surgeries. People phone me or write to me at my office here in Chislehurst..

**'Attracting investment in Thamesmead will create jobs'**

**In which direction do you think the company Thamesmead Town (TT) should be moving?**
I think the important thing for the people of Thamesmead is that the Company which deals with their affairs should be run on the most business- like basis. If the Company is able to generate income, it will benefit the people of Thamesmead. Thamesmead needs investment and income is needed for investment.

**What sort of investment do you see Thamesmead attracting?**
From the outside, I see Thamesmead attracting investment in the industrial and manufacturing area (which will create jobs) and in the commercial sector, such as development of a new shopping or leisure centre. I feel, however that Thamesmead Town itself needs to invest in the area.

**What sort of investment do you feel TT should be making?**
Money needs to be spent on clearing contaminated land for development. It may be possible to get grants for this but there will still be costs left with Thamesmead Town. Money also needs to be spent on infrastructure and leisure facilities and improvements for the Town's social life.

**This investment is going to cost money, where is this money going to come from?**
One development has to follow another. That is why it is in the interests of everyone in Thamesmead that the Company should be commercially successful.

**Are you satisfied that TT is moving in the right direction?**
Yes, having discussed with Sir James Mellon his plans for Thamesmead, I am. The Company has suffered tremendously from the appalling drop in land and property values, but I understand that measures are now being taken which will restore the Company to proper financial balance.

**'Young people need to learn more about the way the European Union works'**

**Do you think land values will rise?**
Yes, I think we've reached the bottom and things are now beginning to move up. That will help the Company but that there are other things that will have to be done in order to maximise the possible benefits.

**When you're out and about as an MEP, do you put in a good word for Thamesmead?**
Yes, certainly. We campaigned for the East Thames Corridor to be designated for European Regional Aid, but were unsuccessful. I hope that we will be able to get the ETC scheduled at the next review in 1996. Thamesmead stands to gain, as part of the funds could be released for making the area more attractive for development.

**Following recent changes in trade law, could European Companies soon be investing in Thamesmead?**
Absolutely, I hope that there will be a good chance of that! This is taking place throughout the European Union. Some changes haven't yet come into effect in certain States, and the recession has dampened down investment, but as we move out of recession, we will see more investment and the true Single Market concept will become evident to everybody.

**It is very expensive funding an MEP because you have to travel between three cities. Do the people in Thamesmead get a good return on their money?**
Democracy costs money. The European constituency is much larger than that local MPs, so the cost of an MEP is a only fraction of the amount for representation in the House of Commons.



***Peter with daughter Myfanwy aged 2***

**Some people might say they only get a fraction of the return from an MEP.**
Firstly, the countries of Europe have fought each other through the centuries. The purpose of the European Community is to bring together the peoples of Europe so that there will never be another war. We must build a sense of unity so we need people joining forces in Europe who are linked right back to the grass roots. Secondly, I am trying to ensure good value for the money paid into Europe by the residents of Thamesmead and the rest of my constituents. I am a member of several committees which determine how funds are distributed. Some trade matters, for example the GAT talks, cannot be entered into at the level of member states. When dealing with partners such as Japan and the USA, we are stronger as a community.

**How should the children of Thamesmead be preparing for adulthood in a single market economy?**
People in general, and young people in particular, ought to learn more about the European Union and how it functions. At present, most people don't know how decisions are taken at the European level which leads to a sense of alienation. The subject seems complicated because not enough is taught about it at schools. There needs to be an understanding that British MEPs play leading roles, not just in stopping things from happening, but in making things happen. Young people can prepare for the future by learning languages. German has become much more important and I think our schools ought to have a balance between teaching French, German and Spanish.

**The Thamesmere Leisure Centre has recently committed itself to a new Customer Charter. We went down to the Centre to find out what was on offer.**

# SHAPE UP AT THE CO-OP



**BE SLIMMER, BE FITTER, BE HEALTHIER, BE A MEMBER** said the large banner outside the Thamesmere Leisure Centre. Situated in Thamesmere Drive, the exterior of the place looks rather smart and modern and the pleasant air-conditioned foyer matches, with a friendly atmosphere and Swedish-style pine waiting chairs. Mark Drake, one of the Centre's duty managers, met us and showed us around. He is going to University once a week to study for a degree in Exercise and Health.

**Mark** says that the Centre is not just geared to super-fit people. 'We don't just want to make the fit fitter. There is something for everyone. People of all abilities can come along and improve their level of fitness. As a result they will experience better lifestyles.'

**With** all this on offer, why are some people so scared of starting a fitness regime and how can they overcome this fear?
'When people think of a gym they think of someone young and fit and sometimes that can put them off. What people need to remember is that everyone has to go through the stage of being unfit and possibly overweight before they become fitter and slimmer. The most difficult task is getting people to come in for the first time. Obviously if people are greeted and given the right tuition they will come back, and they'll be the ones that encourage their friends to come.'

**Any other motivational tips?**
'I always say that the hardest part of the workout is leaving home. Once a person has gone home, had something to eat, and watched a bit of telly, the last thing they want to do is go out again to the gym. If people come straight from work, have a workout and then go home they feel great, and they want to do it more and more.'

**The Centre** provides exercise classes for all levels of ability, the level being clearly shown on the timetable. Originally a swimming pool only, the Centre's space has been cleverly re-organised to provide a fitness room (complete with multi-purpose exercise machines, free-weights and Sky Television), an aerobics hall, a crêche, a variety of exercise classes and a sunbed facility. A new air-conditioned sauna suite is about to be fitted and will be ready by August. It will have three sun-beds, an eight-seater sauna, a television (possibly with Sky) and a relaxation area.

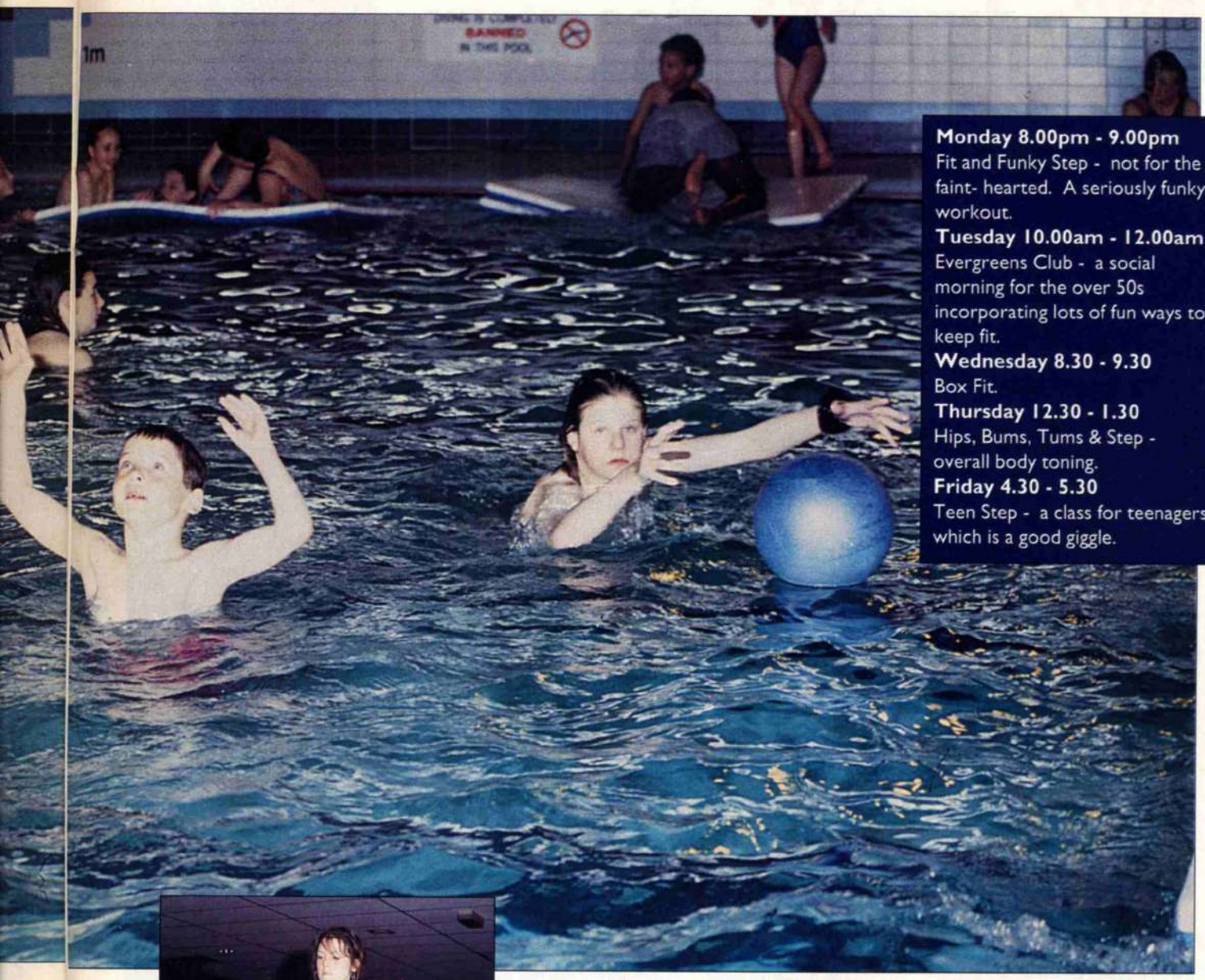
**Also** on the cards is an extension to be built using space from the car park (parking will still be easy). On week-days this will be used for aerobics classes, five-a-side football and so on and on the weekend it will be hired out for community events, such as weddings.

**Among** the Centre's most popular classes is the 'Ultimate Fat Burner'.

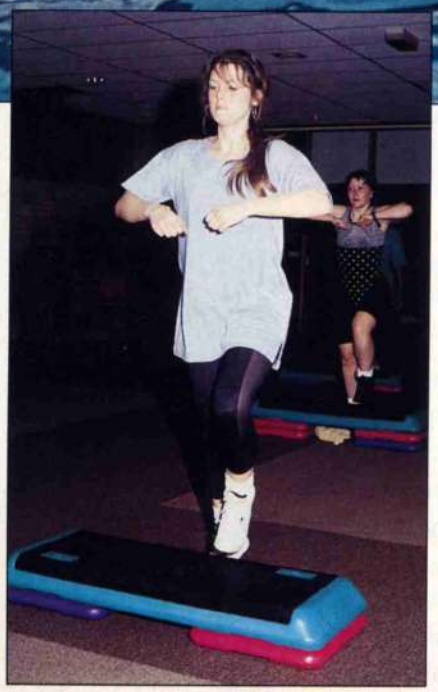
**'Box-fit'** is also popular, so much so that the Centre is now starting a second class. It is a non-combative combination of boxing and aerobics. Perhaps surprisingly, this also attracts a lot of females. Mark describes it as 'a bit of aerobics and taking aggression out on the bag. Great for building up confidence'.

**The Centre** is also rented out to clubs such as the Triathlete Club - for seriously fit and determined athletes only. Some of the Centre's regular attenders are on the GP Referral Scheme, under which a doctor refers a patient who could benefit from regular exercise. A lot of over 50s surprise themselves after a couple of weeks. And there's plenty for children to get involved in too.

**The Centre** has recently changed from Council ownership to cooperative status. Leisure Centres are not the most remunerative facilities and it is doing comparatively well. Greenwich Leisure Ltd rents the building from the London Borough of Greenwich, while




**Monday 8.00pm - 9.00pm**
Fit and Funky Step - not for the faint- hearted. A seriously funky workout.
**Tuesday 10.00am - 12.00am**
Evergreens Club - a social morning for the over 50s incorporating lots of fun ways to keep fit.
**Wednesday 8.30 - 9.30**
Box Fit.
**Thursday 12.30 - 1.30**
Hips, Bums, Tums & Step - overall body toning.
**Friday 4.30 - 5.30**
Teen Step - a class for teenagers which is a good giggle.



the Board is made up of workers, councillors and representatives from the public. GLL have recently launched their first client charter and are very careful to make sure that standards are maintained in the building!

**Compared** to the equivalent private club with similar equipment, the Centre is cheap. Recently, prices have been changed so that even people who do not live in Greenwich pay the lower amount that used to be the privilege of Borough residents. A year's membership now costs £20 for a an employed adult and £10 for a child. There are cheap rates for the unemployed, students, people on Income Support and OAPs. Membership entitles you to large discounts on all activities. For example, members pay £3.30 for most lessons. Teenagers pay just £1 for Teen Step.

**Readers** who want improve their fitness levels can work in the fitness room, swim or attend the organised classes. A few of these are listed on this page, to give a taste of what's on offer. But remember, this is only a small selection of the many activities on offer. Here's to gain, rather than pain!

• Crêche facilities are available for all lunch-time classes. To find out more call the Centre on 081-311 1119.

# Bill's dramatic discovery

**Soon Thamesmead residents will be able to visit an exciting exhibition based on an important archaeological find in Slocum Close. We talked to Thamesmead resident Bill McCann, who supervised the excavation.**



*Excavating the neolithic platform at the Slocum Close site*

Bill McCann says that you can always tell an archaeologist, because they are forever looking into holes. A Thamesmead resident for the past 11 years, he is a Senior Archaeologist at the Museum of London, and a theatre director to boot.

Bill usually has to travel quite far to dig for relics and, until last summer, he used to peer dreamily into holes when building work was going on in Thamesmead, wishing that he could explore further but not holding out much hope. After all, there had never been a modern archaeological excavation in the area.

> " Bill knew he would only have three chances - after that he would have to give up "

Then, on July 20 last year, Bill's boss got a phone call which was to lead to Bill's dream coming true. An archaeologist monitoring the Slocum Close site where Countryside Properties were building homes for Hexagon Housing Association, had found 'something interesting'.

On July 28 Bill and his team were sent to the site to explore further.

Hexagon had kindly agreed to pay for the necessary digging, but Bill knew that he was allowed to make just three holes, anywhere he wanted, and if nothing was then found, he would have to give up the search. There was only one problem: the surface gave no indication where any possible remains could be buried. At random, Bill picked a spot. A JCB digger was used to make a hole four metres deep. It held nothing unusual.

> "The JCB got going and this time it struck something solid"

Knowing he had only two more choices, with the same nervous uncertainty with which a television game show contestant opts for what they hope is the winning number, Bill pointed to another spot. The JCB got going and this time it struck something solid.

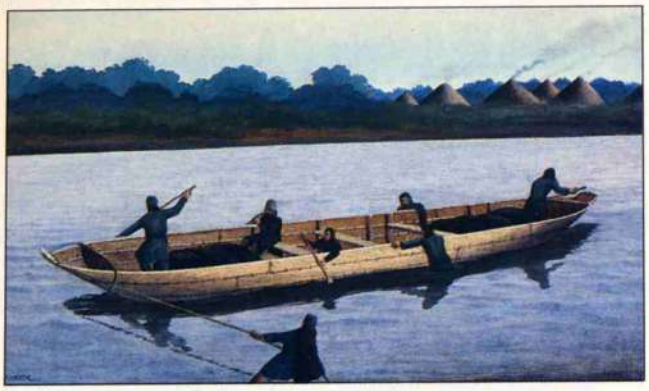
The excited excavation workers and the JCB operator hastily carried on digging. Some hours later several long pieces of wood were revealed, woven together in a type of platform. The Neolithic peat and the fact that the wood was interlaced, meant that this was a man-made structure from the beginning of the Neolithic period. It was about five thousand years old.

How did Bill feel when he found the wood? 'Thrilled, absolutely thrilled.'

Over the following few days the team worked to uncover the massive structure, took photographs and analysed the soil. Once they had discovered all they could, the structure was once more covered and the building of the homes continued. Slocum Close residents will be living, cooking and eating over

## What was found on the site and what it meant.

- Large tree trunks woven together. Archaeologists were already fairly certain that in the Stone Age period Thamesmead, and the surrounding area, was made up of waterlogged marshland with small islands with alder trees growing on them, the interlaced wood was built as a platform, from which people could fish.
- Burnt flint stones. These show that people probably cooked on the platform. The stones would have been heated until they were red hot in the fire then put in a container of water to boil it. Small chips of flint were also found, which would have chipped off in the heat of the fire.
- Charcoal. Further evidence of cooking. Also implies that people had been burning trees in nearby Abbey Wood (the charcoal would have blown over) to prepare for agriculture.
- Hazelnut kernels. People would have been eating the nuts with their meal. This also gives an indication of the trees in the area at the time.
- Layers of peat and river silt. Dating back to 5,000 BC, this peat gives archaeologists a better idea of what the ecology was like in the Thamesmead area at the time.





***Above: An imaginary scene showing how Thamesmead would have looked in neolithic times. Right: A neolithic axe found in Erith. The handle is reconstructed but the head is original.***

## About Bill McCann



**Bill did not start his scientific career as an Archaeologist. He has a degree in Chemistry and used to be a Chemist, working on a Ministry of Defence contract at Imperial College.**

**By working as a volunteer on various archaeological digs, he gradually transferred his expertise and eventually got a job at the Museum of London. Does he see the past in scientific terms only?**

**'Definitely not.' he answers emphatically. 'We Archaeologists are not that boring. Archaeology is about people, discovering how they lived their lives and the type of environments that surrounded them.'**

**How does Bill spend his leisure time?**

**Amateur dramatics, amateur dramatics and more amateur dramatics. Both of Bill's parents were Opera singers and actors, and as early as Bill can remember, he was involved with the theatre. In latter times, he has moved to working behind the scenes, mostly directing and prompting, but he willingly goes on stage in his capacity as an understudy. He has just completed of a run of 'A Funny Thing Happened On The Way To The Forum', by Steven Sondheim, with the Lensbury Theatre, performed at the Shell Centre. He is now hoping to start up a Thamesmead amateur dramatics society, which will be called Theatre Thamesmead. Anyone interested in joining should contact Thamesmead Town Public Relations Department, which will put you in touch with Bill.**

the very site where people cooked and ate five thousand years ago.

But who were these people?

'They were neolithic hunters and gatherers who were just beginning to plant seeds to produce edible crops. We know that in the Thamesmead area they hunted, fished and fowled from small islands, dotted around marshlands. Last century a neolithic boat, rather like a modern-day canoe, was found in nearby Belvedere, which could have been used to travel to the platform we found. A pot was also found in neighbouring Erith.' Bill shows us a reconstruction of the Erith pot which is decorated with a very pretty design, a bit like a pot you might find in Habitat, or Marks and Spencer.

But what did they actually achieve?

'Their greatest achievement,' says Bill, 'is us. If these people had not survived, we would not be around. People say 'well, they were stupid, they didn't build any great buildings' but despite living on a marsh, in terrible weather conditions, with wild animals stalking them, no modern medicine, an extremely high rate of infant mortality and a low adult life expectancy, these people fought to survive, and we've that to thank them for.

'Remember, too, that very little had been discovered for them. Imagine trying to bake a cake, never having seen a cake or being given a recipe. You couldn't do it. Prehistoric man's early innovations paved the way for the technology that we have today.'

What language did they speak and what did it sound like?

'We don't know exactly, because there was no writing. That's why that time is called prehistoric, because it came before written historical records. Having said that, the language would have been a type of proto-Celtic, the nearest modern example being Irish Gaelic.'

Thamesmead children will be able to find out more about the discovery, and about the subject of prehistoric man in an exhibition, sponsored by Thamesmead Town.

## Time Scale

**• Palaeolithic Age 4,500-8,000 BC. At this time, Britain was still joined to European continent. People would come across the land bridge in the summer to hunt and gather.**

**• Mesolithic Age 8,000- 3,000 6,500 BC. Following the last Ice Age, Britain was separated from the Continent. People were hunting and gathering and made much more refined tools. A bone awl from this time was found at Crossness in the 19th Century.**

**• Neolithic Age 3,500- 1,800 BC. For the first time people learnt to plant seeds in an early form of agriculture. They also made polished hand axes and ornamented pottery. They domesticated dogs and kept pigs to eat.**

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Save-a-Can welcome ALL TYPES OF DRINK AND FOOD CANS, REGARDLESS OF SIZES OR METAL CONTENT and every tonne of cans recovered earns a donation from Save-a-Can to The Mayor's Charity Fund. The more cans deposited in the skips the greater the donation to charity



Just a few moments spent washing your cans and squashing them if possible, and putting them in your nearest Save-a-Can skip, will pay dividends - by saving metal for re-use, saving energy and protecting the local environment, as well as leaving more room in your dustbin for REAL rubbish.

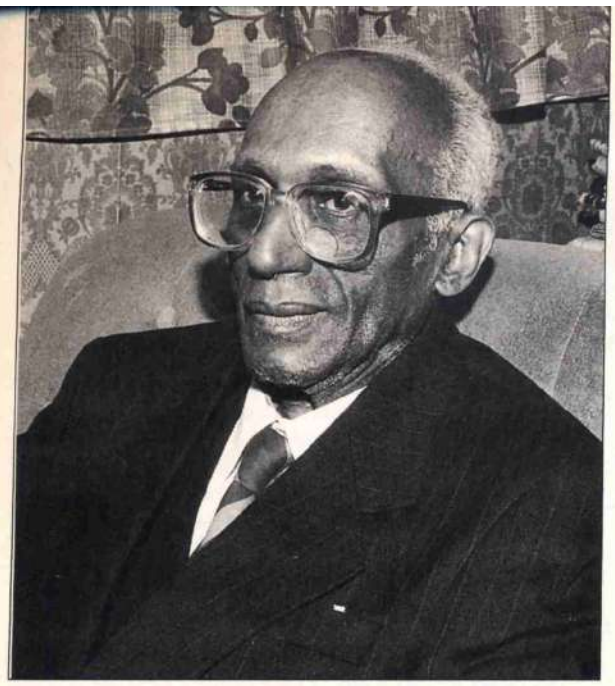
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- SAVE valuable land from being used for tipping
- SAVE quarrying the countryside for raw materials
- SAVE energy, because recycled glass melts at a lower temperature than raw materials

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081-855 5007



# Claude Ramsey MBE

**When Claude Ramsey arrived in England one grey day in 1956, he was totally alone and friendless. A few weeks ago, 28 years on, he went to Buckingham Palace to collect an MBE from the Queen. We visited him at his home in Thamesmead.**

When we met Claude Ramsey two days after he had received an MBE, he did not seem inclined to boast about his achievements. I asked him how he had gone from such an unpromising start in this country to gaining so much respect from the community. Little by little, his story emerged.

One of seven children, Claude was born in Barbados in 1922. His Father was a Senior Clerk in the Barbadian Department of Agriculture. On leaving school, Claude joined the same department. Later he was a reporter for the Barbados Reporter. Appalled by the amount of 'barefooted destitution and misery' surrounding him, the 'starvation and hunger' and the injustice of a largely white leadership of a mostly black population, Claude became interested in politics, and joined the Barbadian Labour movement. He felt strongly about the blanket dominance of the middle and upper classes. But wasn't he himself from the middle classes?

'Yes,' he admits, 'but I became something of an outcast because I did not support the status quo as it was then.'

In 1950 Claude married his wife Gabriel. Soon, he had a son and wife to support. The poor economic situation in Barbados and the prospect of work made him decide to move to England. Forced to leave his wife at home, in 1956 he went ahead to find a job.

Having expected the 'mother country' to fulfil her promise of an open- armed welcome, Claude walked off the ship to a rude awakening. He had been told that a place would be reserved for him at a Salvation Army hostel, only to discover that no booking had been made. It was late in the evening and he was left to fend for himself on his first night in England.

Claude found a job in the storeroom of a shoe shop and a room in Notting Hill Gate, sharing a bathroom and toilet with 30 other people. From this he found better accommodation and was helped by some English friends he had made at the shoe store.

**"Ramsey was appalled by the barefooted destitution surrounding him"**

Eventually, his wife joined him and they had another child, this time a daughter. Very soon, he became involved with his local community.

West Indians at that time had to face up to prejudice constantly, and there were few organisations to take their part. Claude heard Oswald Mosley, the fascist, speak. . 'Don't fool yourself,' he says, 'he was one of the greatest orators of our time. But I thought to myself, "I didn't know that we are that horrible."' This is typical of Claude's humour and calm resistance to prejudice.

Following the death of Kelso Cochrane, a West Indian who was murdered while he was out shopping, the West Indian Defence Committee was formed, with Claude as a founder member. Originally, it was set up largely to find lawyers for young black men who had no legal representation but, says Claude, 'There were no other organisations of its kind at the time, so as soon as we did one thing, we had to do everything.'

From there Claude went on to serve on committees and in organisations too numerous to mention. He helped stage the first Notting Hill Carnival, and branched out from helping West Indians to union work, over a period of 16 years becoming variously the Chairman and the Secretary of the 1,000-strong Dulwich branch of NUPE, also serving on the National Committee. Through work on other committees, he met Lord Fenner Brockway and Lord Fisher.

In 1978 Claude took early retirement and in 1980 bought a house in Thamesmead, where he still lives with his wife. Needless to say, he was not idle, and he was soon committed to serving, and being involved in, the Thamesmead community. In 1985, he helped to organise the first Multicultural Carnival in Thamesmead, which attracted 40,000 people. He has been, at various times, a Governor of Waterfield Secondary, Windrush, Hawksmoor and Bishop Robinson schools. He is currently the Chairman of the Thamesmead Advisory Forum and has been involved in Trust Thamesmead and the Thamesmead Race Equality Forum.

How does Claude feel about living in Thamesmead?

'It has had a bad press, but things are changing and I have always got on well with the people in Thamesmead, so I like it.'

What direction would he like to see Thamesmead moving in in the future?

'I'd like to see more development and I'd like to see more people moving here. I'd also like to see a new community building built here. I am optimistic about Thamesmead's future.'



***Claude at Buckingham Palace***

Looking through various books, we discover that Claude is also the author of a published book called 'Heros All' and a Foreign Correspondent for The Advocate, the Barbadian national newspaper. There seems to be no end to the amount of work he has done.

As we leave Claude's home, he is about to set off to celebrate Maundy Thursday. We say that an OBE will surely follow the MBE 'Oh no,' he says , 'that would be greedy. I just thank God for what I've got.'

# contacts

**Thamesmead Town**
081- 310 1500

**Plumstead Police Division**
081- 855 1212

**Bexley Access Group**
081- 303 8937

**St Paul's Centre**
Bentham Road, Central Thamesmead
halls, rooms and kitchens for hire
081- 310 6814

**Tavy Bridge Senior Citizens' Social Club**
Senior Citizens' Dwellings, Tavy Bridge
New members welcome
Bingo, raffles, tea, biscuits
Every Tuesday from 1pm
Call Roy on 081- 310 1133

**Over 50s Social Club**
Greenmead Clubroom, Lime Row
Every Monday and Thursday. Bingo tickets on sale 7pm, eyes down 7.30pm.
Entrance 20p members, 50p non members.

**Parent & Toddler Group**
Broadwaters Community Centre
Every Thursday 9.15am - 11.15am
Contact Lisa on 081- 316 6479 or Julie on 081- 854 0062

**Arthritis Care**
Jubilee Centre
Lytton Strachey Path (off Titmuss Avenue)
Activities and general social events
Everybody welcome
Every Tuesday 2pm - 4pm

**Jolly Tots**
Jubilee Centre
For parents and toddlers
10am - 12 noon
081- 310 2632

**Thamesmead Toy Library**
Manor Close Community Hall (off Crossway)
Every Wednesday morning from 9am-2pm
Toys available on loan for disabled, handicapped and sick children in Thamesmead

**Shokotan Karate**
Manor Close Hall
(off Crossway)
Thursday evenings
6.30-7.30pm 5-12 year olds
7.30 - 8.30pm Men, Women and over 13s

## Director's Surgeries

**Broadwaters (Area 1)**
Ray Hutchins
Heronsgate School Ground Floor
Whinchat Road
2nd Saturday 11am- 12 noon

**Moorings (Area 3)**
Carol Foster
Thamesmere Pools
Thamesmere Drive
On for 3 Saturdays
Off for 3 Saturdays
(phone 310 1500 and ask for DSU to confirm details)

**Manorway (Area 4)**
Gerry Bright
Sanderling Court
33 Goldcrest Close
Last Saturday of every month
10am - 12 noon

**Southmere (Area 6)**
Stuart Cox
Tavy Bridge
Patch Office
21 March, 25 April
23 May, 20 June
6.30pm - 7.30pm

**Lesnes (Area 7)**
Pat Daniels
Area Patch Office
Evenlode House
Coralline Walk
1st Saturday of every month
10am - 11 am

**Greenmead (Area 9)**
Ian Hathaway
Greenmead Senior Citizens' Clubroom
Lime Row
Last Saturday of every month
10am - 12 noon

• Please note that the surgery times for Crossway, Parkview and Waterfield will follow in the next edition of Thamesmead Focus.

**St John Ambulance**
Friday Evenings
Manor Close Hall
Under 10s (Badgers) 6- 7pm
10- 16 years (Cadets) 7- 9pm
Adults 8.30- 10pm
081- 303 8590

## M.P.s' Surgeries

**John Austin- Walker M.P.** First and third Friday and third Saturday 6pm at 39 Wellington Street, Woolwich. Call 081- 317 9001 for appointment. First Saturday of each month at 11am Thamesmere Leisure Centre.

**David Evenett M.P.** First and third Friday of every month from 7pm at Erith Town Hall. Otherwise contact him at House of Commons 071- 219 4132.

**Thamesmead Citizens' Advice Bureau**
97 Binsey Walk
081- 310 0108

**National Council for Divorced & Separated**
St Michaels Church Hall
Abbey Wood Road
Wednesdays 8- 11pm
Sandie 081- 310 6246
Margaret 081- 311 6096

**Adult Tap Classes**
Manor Close Community Centre
Tuesday evenings
Beginners 7- 8pm Intermediate 8- 9pm

**Crossway Gym Club**
Archway 11,
Byron Close
081- 312 1190

**Bubbles Parent and Toddler Group**
Manor Close Hall
1- 3pm
Monday and Thursday

**Crossway Christian Fellowship**
Manor Close Hall
10am Children of four upwards
11am Mainly for adults

**Thamesmead Christian Fellowship**
Jubilee Centre, Lytton Strachey Path
Every Wednesday Children's Club (6-11 year olds) 6.30- 7.45
Every Friday Youth Club (12- 16 year olds) 7.45- 9.30pm

**Thamesmead Boxing Club**
Poplar Place (rear of boiler house)
11 year olds and over welcome
Monday, Wednesday and Friday
6.30pm - 8.30pm

This is only a selection of information for the Thamesmead area. If would you like your community group to be featured in Focus Contacts, please write to the Editor, Thamesmead Focus, Thamesmead Town, Harrow Manor Way, Thamesmead South, SE2 9XH, with full details.

# Versapak takes the urine and makes it pay

A fail- safe security system for drug- testing athletes, manufactured solely in Thamesmead, has been endorsed by the International Amateur Athletic Federation. It is a feather in the cap for Versapak International, a Thamesmead-based company which last year produced a turnover of £6 million as a leading supplier of mail room equipment. As world leaders in their new field, Versapak now looks set to obtain the entire testing equipment contract for the 1996 Olympics in Atlanta, USA.

The state-of-the-art drug testing system was used throughout the Lillehammer Winter Athletics. Following the kit's success at the Games, the IAAF wrote Versapak into its guidelines for the 205 Member Federations.

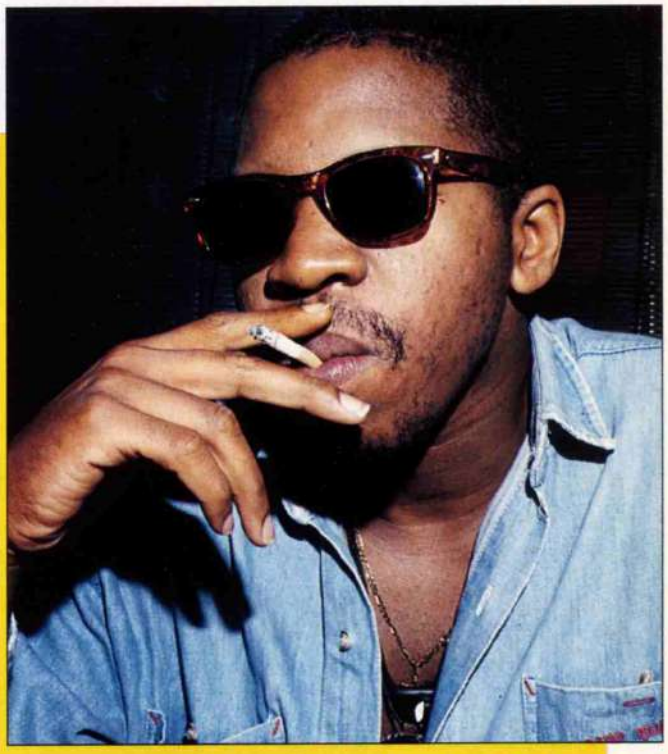
Versapak Managing Director, Mike Anderson, invented the kit. Having been asked by the organisers of the 1991 Rugby World Cup to supply a system whereby samples could not be tampered with, he realised that the methods were unreliable and that there was a gap in the market for a better system. But why is security so important?

'Previously we made containers for the safe transport of cash, but in this case the security of blood and urine represented a higher cash value than cash itself. For example Butch Reynolds, the world-record-holding 400 metre runner received over £15 million in compensation after he was prevented from competing because of faulty tests.'

Having supplied his first attempt to the RWC, Anderson set about developing the current product. Based on the age-old concept of the breakable seal (Medieval Kings used sealing wax stamped with a Royal emblem to ensure that their mail was not tampered with) the Versapak system consists of a plastic container that can only be opened by destroying it. It is also micro-wave proof, recyclable, cheap to manufacture, compact and has a cheat proof numbering system.

All world record winners and a random selection of athletes are tested for drugs. Competitors are tested immediately after competing. It can take hours after a long race or a rugby/football game for an athlete to produce the necessary sample. Mike has waited five hours for a Rugby forward to come up with the goods! Athletes are sure to have their doctors, coaches and lawyers with them at the time of testing.

The Versapak kit has already been used for several World Class events and is bought cont...p18



# BOOMING OUT THE SOUNDS

Thamesmead resident Bumni Tokan (alias Boomy) is a DJ and Record Producer, specialising in Soul, Swingbeat and Garage (a recent version of 'Rave') music. He hosts the Breakfast Show on Skyline Radio on Tuesdays and Thursdays and regularly spins the records at The Clique, at Church's Wine Bar on Kensington Church Street.

The most recent record he has produced, 'Happiness', sung by American singer Janeen Jewett, has received air play on Kiss FM and is set to go big-time. Boomy also produces a singer called Martin, who sounds a bit like Snoop Doggy Dog (an American Rap artist). Boomy works as a producer by listening to the singer's voice and then working with the singer to create the best sound. Is Boomy a singer as well? 'Hell no!'

Having acquired a B.A. in Business Studies, Boomy was awarded a loan from the Prince's Youth Business Trust to help him get started on his career as a Producer. He says that his main objective in producing a record is to create something that will be sold. He regards himself first and foremost as a business man, but says that what he wants most is to make money doing what he enjoys, which is making music. On his radio show he includes motivational catch phrases that he hopes will help young people to achieve their goals.

As a nightclub DJ, Boomy plays a mixture of mellow and upbeat music, ensuring that punters have a memorable night out. You can catch him at the Bar Rhumba, Shaftesbury Avenue, on May 27.

# diary dates

## THAMESMEAD ADVISORY FORUM

**May 29** Boot Fair 9am-2pm Birchmere Park. Who knows what bargains may be found at the Fair?

**July 23** 10am-5pm Family Fun Day Southmere Park. Children's entertainment, drum majorettes, five- a-side football and lots of fun for all generations.

## TRUST THAMESMEAD

**September 18** Birchmere Park. Thamesmead Town Show. More details to follow in the Thamesmead Focus Summer issue.

## THE ORCHARD, DARTFORD (bookings 0322 220000)

**May 9 - 10** English National Ballet. Three mini- ballets including ballet, folk, tap and jazz styles, the last one written and performed by Wayne Sleep. Tickets eves £12.50 - £16.50 concs available for groups, children, oaps.

**May 14** Howard Keel, back by public demand, on his latest UK tour. Tickets £15.50 - £17.50.

**May 27 - 29** Sesame Street Live - Where's The Birdie? Sheer fun and sparkling entertainment for all the family. Tickets £7.50 (adults) £5.00 (children). Family ticket for four £22.00.

**May 31 - June 4** Murder Once Done. Casualty's Catherine Shipton and East Enders' Elizabeth Power star in a new thriller by Richard Harris. When strange things start happening to Julia, a high flying professional, she starts to doubt her own mind, and whether she is being punished for the guilty secret she harbours. Tickets matinee £8.50 - £9.50 or eves £10.50 - £12.50 concs available.

**June 6 - 7** Mrs Doubtfire (12). A hilarious film starring Robin Williams (remember Nanoo- Nanoo?) as a father so desperate to see his children that he dresses up as a woman. Tickets £4.00 (adult) £2.00 children.

**June 13 - 18** Schindler's List (15) Moving Oscar- winning film about a businessman who saved the lives of over a thousand jews during the Second World War. Tickets £4.00.

## BLACKHEATH CONCERT HALLS

(listed events have disabled access) Tel 081- 463 0100

**May 10,** 2pm Great Hall Tea Dance with the Dave Kent trio. Go along and dance to the live music from the Dave Kent Trio. Included in the entrance fee is tea, cake and entry into the raffle. Tickets £3.00 (£2.50 oaps).

**June 4** Penguin Cafe Orchestra. A mixture of styles from this famous band. Tickets £15 (£5 concs).

**Sunday, May 8** Thames Barrier 10th Anniversary Family Fun Day. Face- painting, barbecue, Jelly Rollers Band, Noddy, and many other attractions.

**June 3-12** Greenwich Festival Hotline for programme and bookings 081-317 8687

**July 1 - 2** St Paul's Ecumenical Centre will host 'Rainbow Days', a multi- cultural event bringing together entertainment, crafts and themes from all over the world. See page 23 for details of how to become involved.

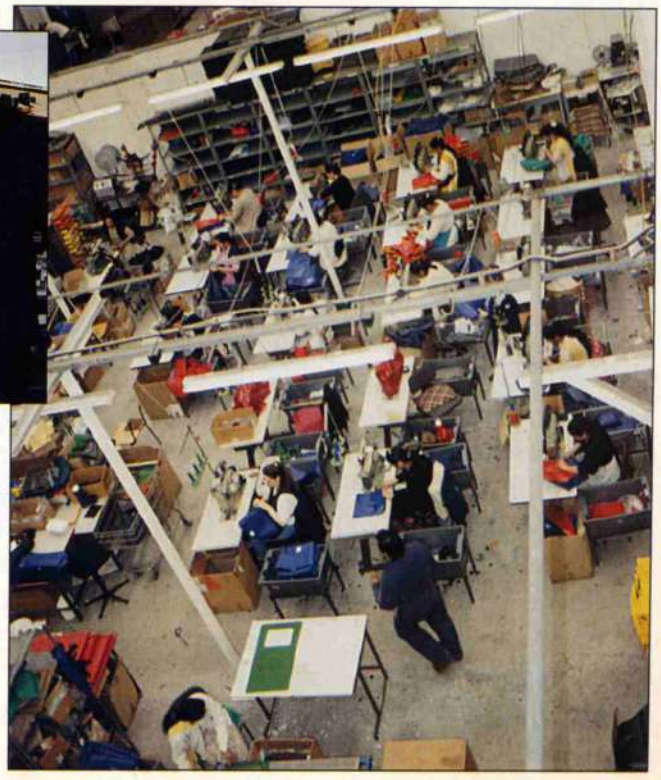
# focus on business

...cont from p17

by 15 countries World-wide. Now that the IAAF has approved the system, it will be hard for any country to avoid using it. The USA alone tests 100,000 samples a year, and 1996 beckons.

• Mike Anderson and his brother Ian started Versapak in 1973 in a room above an Indian takeaway by making envelopes by night and selling them in the daytime. Today the company employs 120 people at its factory which was purpose- built three years ago at Thamesmead's Eastern Industrial Estate. Why did Mike chose the area? 'For its easy access to London and main motorways and for its 'chimney pots'. That is, an employable workforce living within walking distance.' How does he find his new workforce? 'Great. The best we've ever had.'





***Mike and a kit worker with the containers Right: an aerial view of part of the factory floor***

# FOOD FOR THOUGHT

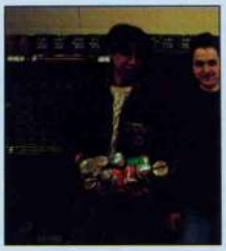
**Do you ever find yourself peaking into other people's shopping baskets, wondering what they're having for tea? We looked into some trolleys at the Thamesmead Branch of Safeways**

## Lisa Revell and grandson



Lisa was in the store with her daughter and grandsons Ryan, 6, and Tom, 4. She drives from her home in Abbey Wood to the store 'because it's convenient, safe for the children and the parking is free'. Lisa's trolley had enough salad and fruit in it to keep 20 rabbits or one health fanatic going for a fortnight. She comes up once a week for a large shop. Is health a big consideration? 'Now that I'm retired, I like home cooking and I go for low- cholesterol, semi- vegetarian food with lots of pulses, bread, fruit, vegetables and fish.' Usually, Lisa and her grandchildren would go to Thamesmere Leisure Centre (across the road) for a swim after shopping, but Ryan had grommets in his ears, so they gave it a miss this week.

## Chi-Hang Chan



Chi- Hang, 20, has lived for three years with his sister in Thamesmead. He is studying architecture at Greenwich University, so he was looking for cheap, convenient food. His basket held one tin of spaghetti letters and two tins each of ravioli, peas and sweetcorn. All of it was going to be eaten with pasta or rice. What does Chi- Hang's mother think of his diet? 'Not very much, she wouldn't think it was very balanced!' Would he be buying anything from the drinks section? 'I'm not sure if my grant stretches that far.'



## Evonne Pechey

Darren, 9, said 'Will you take a picture of me?' So we did. His mum, Evonne, was in the store with Darren and his friend Terry. Although Evonne lives in Thamesmead, she usually does her weekly shop in Bexleyheath or Woolwich, but she was in the store to pick up some 'bits and pieces', such as dog food and milk. She drops in because she knows where everything is. What she makes this week will depend on how much time she has, but she will make at least one roast meal.



## Joy Davy

Joy, 28, and daughter Samantha, 4, travel from Plumstead to visit the store for their weekly shop 'because parking is easy, there's no hassle, there aren't lifts and the fresh produce is good'. Joy's husband has his own Company, repairing microwave ovens, and Joy stays at home to look after their two daughters. Joy prefers home cooking to convenience food, not so much because of health, but because it tastes better and she can add lots of garlic. This week she will be making lasagna, chicken and pork meals. Joy said she usually avoids red meats, but later on we caught up with her looking through the beef section!

# Jointly Promoting

**Greenwich and Bexley Health Promotions service are about to merge.**

The aim of the new service will be to help the people of Thamesmead and surrounding areas become more knowledgable, better motivated and more able to prevent illness and thus enjoy good health.

The present range of services include:

- *The free loan of health promotion resources and supply of educational materials such as leaflets, posters and videos (some of which are produced in house).*
- *The advice and assistance with the use of these materials.*
- *The provision of training courses, study days, conferences and seminars.*
- *The provision of information and to maintain effective communication with the public.*
- *The selection, design, implementation and evaluation of health promotion programmes in priority areas of disease prevention.*
- *The development and co-ordination of health promotion policies, programmes and activities (eg, workplace policies).*
- *Research and evaluation covering consumer surveys.*
- *Community development, working with local groups and associations to support their activities on health issues.*

**One such development is the Waterfront Health Action Project (WHAP) based at the William Temple Church, which has a drop-in centre open every Tuesday morning.**

Last year WHAP carried out a survey to find out what the health concerns of the area were.

Some of the results of this extensive survey showed that pollution, smoking, traffic smells and noise were amongst the main concerns having harmful effects on health and that diet, family and friends, open spaces and exercise were beneficial for good health.

Using this information and statistical data gathered from other sources, analysis showed a high incidence of childhood asthma. As a direct result of these findings, the health promotion team works with school nurses and teachers to make sure children with asthma can cope with their predicament and that members of staff can recognise and act quickly and effectively when symptoms show.

People were also shown to be worried about smoking and passive smoking. The health promotion team have always been warning about the harmful effects of tobacco smoking but have improved their service by adding to their normal promotion work, 'Stopping Smoking Classes'. Here they support people who want to stop and give advice on how to give up. They actively have stop smoking campaigns in several languages and help with the organisation of displays in public places.



*Carl Howman of BBC's Brush Strokes actively promotes good health in the borough.*

# Your Good Health

Healthy eating and or diet was shown to be another concern for good health.

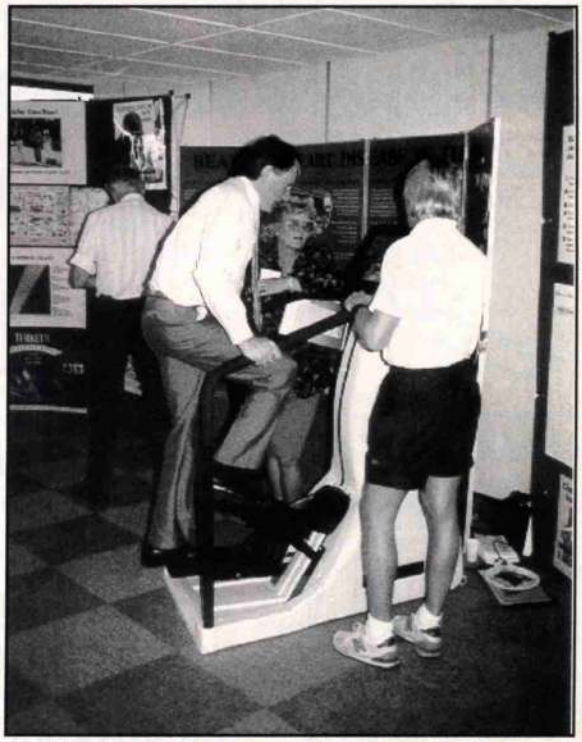
Advice on healthy eating has always been readily available and soon the team will be running a campaign to promote healthy eating. The emphasis will be very much on 'fruit and veg', but also part of this initiative will be a competition for school children as a bonus.

**The Health Promotion team is headed by John Harris assisted by Sue Bradbury and you can often see their helpful and efficient team at shopping centres, fetes etc giving advice and handing out leaflets, running competitions and quizzes, all with the aim of making people aware of the need to look after their health.**

## LOOK AFTER YOUR *HEART*

*The Employers Health Charter*

Employers throughout the country are being actively encouraged to join a new and healthy initiative, 'The Employers Health Charter'. Employers can approach the service with a view to promoting healthy practices and adopting healthy attitudes in their work. It involves the signing of a charter which include such things as providing a healthy choice of food in the works canteen or restaurant, promoting and encouraging exercise and instigating smoke free areas. They are also encouraged to have a workplace alcohol policy. Employers that have signed up in other parts of the country have found a significant reduction in accidents, sickness and staff absenteeism rates and an overall increase in productivity which can only be good news for everyone concerned.



*Dr Alan Maryon Davis watched by Jo Rodin, Chairperson of Greenwich and Bexley Health Authority tries a fitness machine.*

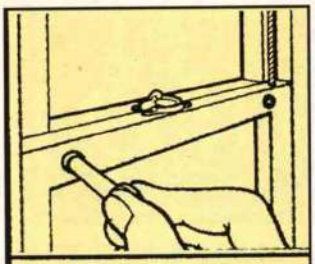
## HIV prevention

*The team plays an active* part in preventing the spread of the HIV virus. They have outreach workers who work with those at greatest risk of contracting the virus and have HIV education visitors for schools. They also actively promote needle exchanges and advice on safe sex.

**If you would like more information on the range of services provided by the Health Promotion team, call our contact points:**

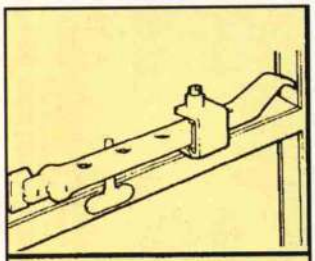
***at Bexleyheath on 081 308 3081***
***or***
***at Eltham on 081 859 8209***

# BASIC HOME SECURITY SERVICES



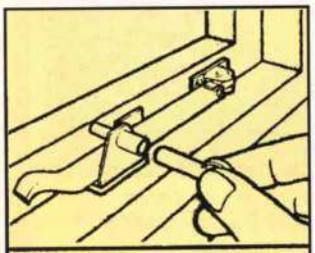
SASH WINDOW SCREW LOCK 826

**@£4.50**



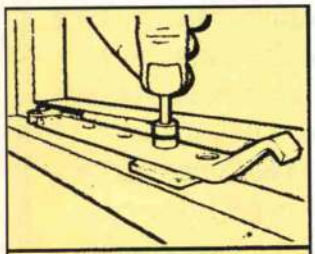
TRANSOM WINDOW LOCK 825

**@£5.00**



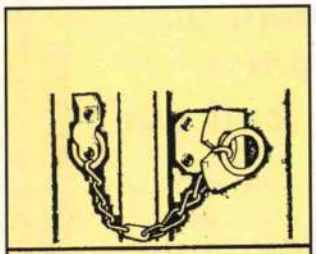
WINDOW STAY BOLT 827

**@£17.00** for 6



WINDOW STAY LOCK 820

**@£3.40**



DOOR CHAIN 788

**@£6.50**

## COSYTOP BASIC HOME SECURITY will SUPPLY and FIT

British Standard Window and Door Locks for what it would cost to buy at your local DIY store

**As a householder you stand a 1 in 20 chance of being burgled this year.**

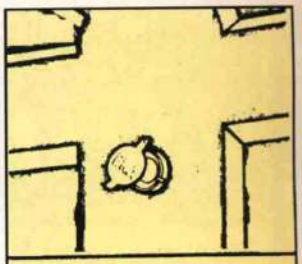
**Burglars don't like locked windows because someone may hear them breaking the glass.**

**A small investment is all that is necessary to provide your vulnerable doors and windows with secure locking devices which would deter thieves looking for an easy break-in.**

**Door Locks • Window Locks • Spy Holes • Door Chains • Smoke Alarms • London Bars**

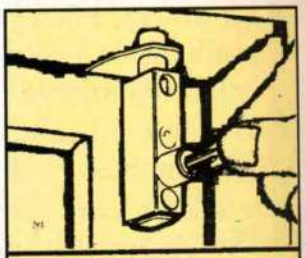
**TO PLACE YOUR ORDER OR FOR MORE INFORMATION ON OUR FULL RANGE OF SECURITY DEVICES CALL...**

**FREEPHONE 0800 373464**



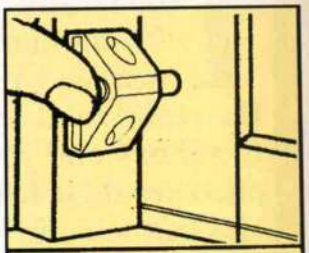
DOOR VIEWER 784

**@£5.00**



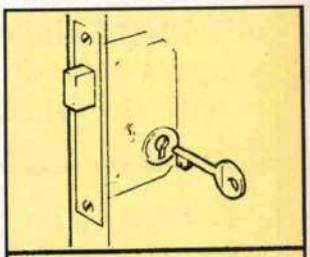
UNIVERSAL PRESS BOLT 805 806

**@£12.00**



PATIO DOOR & WINDOW LOCK 100

**@£14.00**



5 LEVER MORTICE LOCK

**@£42.00**

**All prices include VAT and Fitting**

ADVERTISEMENT

# Join up for Rainbow Days

**Organisers of a two-day multi-cultural event are inviting people to play active roles in a celebration of the rich cultures of the world.**

**The event will be held on Friday 1 and Saturday 2 of July, with the first day devoted to schools.**

**Educational activities will be arranged by the world-famous Adzido dance company. Adzido will perform in the evening at an all-ticket occasion.**

**The programme for the second day is planned as a Family Fun Day.**

**Ideas and contributions for making the day a lively event are welcomed from Community Groups representing various backrounds. The event, called Rainbow Days, will be held at St Pauls Centre, Bentham Road, Thamesmead. Plans are also being made for a cricket match on the Sunday afternoon.**

**Rainbow Days is planned by the Thamesmead Race Equality Forum and sponsored by Thamesmead Town.**

**Event coordinator Reverend Chris Byers would like to hear from potential participants. You can contact him at St Paul's Office at Bentham Road.**
***Tel: 081-310 6814***

# Focus on focus

This is the first issue of Thamesmead Focus, which at present is planned as a quarterly magazine. The magazine will be delivered throughout the area to residents and businesses of Thamesmead.

The aim of the magazine is to report on various activities and developments around the area, to reflect the life of Thamesmead and to feature opportunities in the area, be they business, leisure or social.

Most of all it is hoped that the magazine will be a good read and have something for everyone.

In this issue we have covered, among other subjects, a thriving local Leisure Centre, a resident who has just received the MBE, a £6 million-turnover company , an archaeological dig, and some busy mothers. Thamesmead certainly has a lot going on and hopefully the magazine will be able to reflect this in its future issues.

We would welcome suggestions from residents and business people. If, for example, you have a job vacancy that needs to be filled, contact us and, space permitting, we will include it in the magazine free of charge.

Also if you know anyone who lives or works in Thamesmead who has made a great achievement, or overcome a difficulty, we would like to know.

Please contact us soon if you would like your social or business activities featured in the magazine. Please write to the Editor, Thamesmead Focus, Thamesmead Town, Harrow Manor Way, SE2 9XH.

# job focus

### • HGV Tanker Driver
Age open
Experienced Tanker Driver required. Preferably with ADR certificate.
Wage: £170 per week basic
Times: 39 hours per week + overtime
Area: London Area
Job no: WOW 0386

### • Experienced Muller Operator
Print Finishers require machine operator with minimum of 2 years experience. Must be able to work weekends.
Wage: £15,000 -£18,000 p/a
Times: 37.5 hours per week
(Mon-Fri, Sat paid at overtime)
Area: Thamesmead

### • Experienced Folder Operator
All conditions and wages as above
Job no: WOW 0387

### • Experienced Perspex Binders Operator
All conditions and wages as above
Job no: WOW 0389

### • Legal Secretary
Age 25+
Local solicitors require secretary with at least two years legal experience and audio typing (50wpm)
Wage £11,700 p/a
Tel: 081-854 5333 quoting no. QWA 0348

### • Beautician
Age: open
Fully qualified beautician required for local salon. Minimum 5 years experience. Also experience in body massage and metrolics.
Wage: negotiable according to age and experience
Times: part-time Tues, Weds, Thurs or full time to be arranged
Area: Woolwich
Tel: 081-854 5333, quoting job no QWA 0346

**For all WOW jobs contact Woolwich Arsenal ESJ on 081- 854 2441 extensions 216 or 130, quoting job number.**